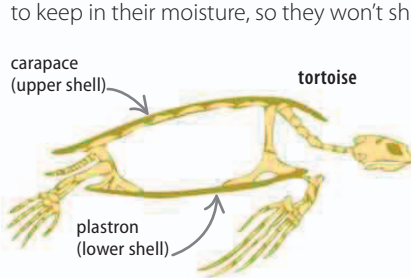


Reptiles

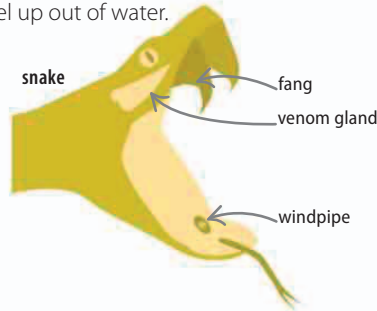
Reptiles were the first vertebrates to make the break from living in water completely. They became the ancestors of birds and mammals as a result. They are a varied group with several distinct branches, but all share two common features. They all have waterproofed keratin scales covering their skin, and their eggs all have waterproof shells to keep in their moisture, so they won't shrivel up out of water.

The Johnstone river turtle breathes underwater by absorbing oxygen through its anus.



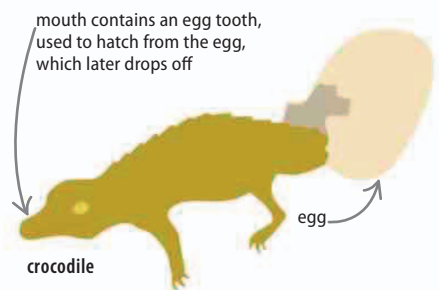
△ Turtles and tortoises

Turtles and tortoises evolved separately from dinosaurs and other reptiles. They have a defensive bony shell covered in giant horny scales (called scutes) attached to the ribs.



△ Squamates

Most of today's reptiles belong to this order, which includes lizards and snakes. Many snakes and a few lizards have venom glands, which are modified salivary glands, used for attacking prey.

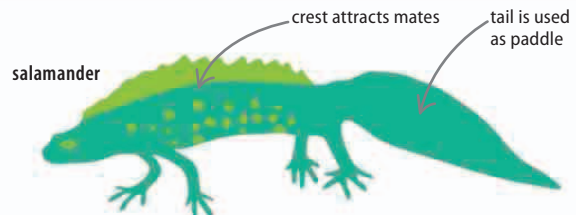


△ Crocodilians

The crocodilians are archosaurs, a group of large reptiles that also included the dinosaurs. They are predatory hunters, waiting for prey to come close before snapping with powerful jaws.

Amphibians

Amphibians were the first creatures to live part of their life on land, evolving about 400 mya. They must return to water or moist habitats to lay eggs. After hatching, most amphibians spend their early growth phase in water, breathing with gills. They then transform—in a process called metamorphosis—into an air-breathing adult form that feeds on land.



△ Newts and salamanders

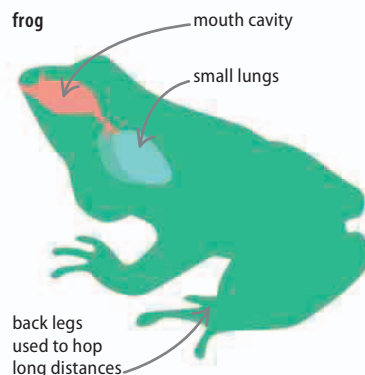
These amphibians were the first vertebrates to evolve a neck. Their neck lets them move their head from side to side, which is different from frogs and toads, who must move their whole body to look left or right.

REAL WORLD

Ectothermy



Fish, amphibians, and reptiles are ectothermic (cold-blooded), meaning their bodies are the same temperature as their surroundings. Ectotherms become more active in warm weather. Reptiles and amphibians influence their temperature by basking in the sun to heat up, or diving into water to cool down.



◁ Frogs and toads

Frogs are hunters that ambush prey using a sticky tongue and huge mouth. They have small lungs, and absorb much of their oxygen through their skin. Toads tend to have warty skin and legs designed for walking, while frogs have smoother skin and legs suited to hopping.